Business Strategy and Analytics

Strategy Proposal for Starbucks

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SL. NO.	TITLE	PAGE NO.
1	**Company Overview**	**3**
1.1	Summary of the organization	3
1.2	Business Model	3
1.3	Current Strategic Position	3
2	**Strategic Opportunity and challenges**	**4**
3	**Proposed strategy**	**5**
4	**Strategic Alignment with Existing Business and Feasibility**	**5**
4.1	Strategic Alignment	5
4.2	Feasibility	6
5	**Validation**	**6**
5.1	Average Customer Ratings	7
5.2	Average Sentiment Polarity	7
5.3	Regression Analysis	9
5.4	Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) Analysis	10
5.5	Other market trends and competitors' analysis	12
6	**Risk Assessment and its Mitigation**	**14**
6.1	Competitors imitating on price	14
6.2	Global Operational Disruption from Localized Strategy Expansion	14
6.3	Staff Behavior/ Trained employee	15
7	**Scenario Analysis**	**15**
8	**Conclusion**	**17**
9	**Use of Generative AI**	**17**
10	**Use of Project Management Tools and Methodologies**	**18**
11	**Attribution Statement**	**20**
12	**Bibliography**	**20**

CONTENT

1. Company Overview

1.1 Summary of the organisation

Starbucks, founded in 1971, is a global leader in the premium coffeehouse market and operates more than 36,000 stores worldwide. In the United Kingdom, Starbucks manages over 1,100 outlets through a hybrid structure of 354 company-owned stores and 814 licensed locations, allowing it to scale rapidly while maintaining brand control. The company's value proposition is built around its iconic "Third Place" concept providing customers with a welcoming space that sits between home and work, designed to offer comfort, community, and consistent product quality. Guided by its mission to "inspire and nurture the human spirit-one person, one cup and one neighbourhood at a time," Starbucks seeks to foster meaningful customer experiences while delivering high quality, ethically sourced coffee. Its vision, to become the world's premier coffee company by creating warm, inclusive environments across its locations, reflects its commitment to both global consistency and locally grounded store experiences.

1.2 Business Model (UK Market)

Starbucks' UK business model focuses on offering premium coffee supported by a consistent global brand experience, a comfortable café environment, and strong digital convenience. Revenue is generated through beverage and food sales, merchandise, loyalty driven repeat visits, and licensing agreements. The brand targets urban professionals, students, and tourists seeking convenience and familiarity. Key activities include ethical sourcing, efficient store operations, menu innovation, and digital platform management. Core resources include its global brand equity, integrated supply chain, and its rewards ecosystem. Starbucks reaches customers through physical stores, its mobile app, delivery services, and drive thru formats. In a competitive market, it rivals Greggs, Costa Coffee, Pret A Manger, and Caffè Nero on convenience, pricing, and loyalty.

1.3 Current Strategic Position (UK Focus)

The current strategic position of Starbucks in the UK reflects its premium brand stance, as pricing remains higher than many local competitors. While enjoying a strong digital ecosystem, adoption rates remain lower than in the US domestic market. Further, the highly

standardized global approach has sometimes led to disconnects with local taste preferences. Starbucks' stores also remain concentrated in urban centres, especially office districts and high-traffic city locations.

Key competitors, such as Costa Coffee, Pret A Manger, and Greggs, currently outperform in key areas: Costa through strong local roots and value pricing, Pret through convenience and speed of service, and Greggs through very low pricing and high purchase frequency. Together, these factors shape Starbucks' current competitive position in the UK, by influencing customer expectations around pricing, speed and overall experience.

2. Strategic Opportunity and Challenge

Starbucks UK is at a pivotal juncture, as the competitive set continues to evolve in response to changing consumer habits and economic dynamics. Increasing price sensitivity in the cost of living crisis has driven consumers toward more affordable competitors, convenience led formats, and in home coffee solutions that offer superior perceived value. This challenge for Starbucks centres not only on reduced footfall but, crucially, on a premium pricing model that risks becoming misaligned with what today's consumer is willing to pay. Unless addressed, this will accelerate market share decline.

Yet this challenge is also a major strategic opportunity. The UK coffee market keeps on growing, and consumers are still happy to engage with brands offering quality, experience, and personalization provided the offering feels fair and accessible. With a strong digital ecosystem, best in class ethical sourcing reputation, and loyal customer base, Starbucks is well-placed to respond.

By resetting value via tiered pricing, personalized digital offers, and operational efficiency, Starbucks can convey affordability without compromising its premium positioning. This, combined with smaller formats, more approachable seasonal beverages, and better in-store execution, these shifts can increase visit frequency and overall relevance. Ultimately, Starbucks' competitive strength in the UK will depend on its ability to adapt to these changing consumer expectations rather than maintain its current, standardised approach.

3. Proposed Strategy

To strengthen its competitive position in the UK, Starbucks should adopt a more customer-focused and locally responsive strategy, beginning with pricing reform. With UK consumers becoming increasingly price sensitive and competitors like Greggs and Costa offering strong value, Starbucks' premium pricing risks limiting repeat purchases. Introducing regional pricing, value-tier drink options, and loyalty bundles or subscriptions would help maintain its premium positioning while reducing cost perception barriers.

Alongside pricing, Starbucks should deepen localisation to better reflect UK café culture. The current experience feels largely Americanised, which may not fully align with British preferences for slower paced café visits and familiar flavours. Offering regionally inspired menus, expanding UK style bakery and food options, and redesigning certain stores for relaxed seating and hybrid work would create stronger emotional relevance.

Improving service experience is also essential. Competitors often outperform Starbucks on friendliness and speed, so enhanced customer service training, incentivised engagement, and greater store-level autonomy during peak hours would help build consistency and loyalty.

Finally, Starbucks could increase cultural integration and profitability by partnering with or investing in successful local cafés, regional suppliers, or community-based formats. This approach positions Starbucks as part of the UK café ecosystem rather than a global chain imposed on it.

4. Strategic Alignment with Existing Business and Feasibility

4.1 Strategic Alignment

The proposed strategy aligns closely with Starbucks' vision, values, and organisational capabilities. Starbucks emphasises courage and a willingness to innovate, making pricing reform, regional menu adaptation, and service enhancement consistent with its culture of experimentation and continuous improvement. The company also values joy and seeks to "bring out the best in each other," which directly supports initiatives focused on improving employee development and elevating customer service quality. Strengthening barista customer interactions reinforce Starbucks' identity as a welcoming "third place" and enhances both the employee and customer experience. Local market adaptation further reflects Starbucks' global operating model, as the company already tailors' menus and pricing structures across major international markets. With strong UK market presence, established supply chain scale, these

initiatives align naturally with Starbucks' commitment to community, innovation, and customer centricity.

Implementation requirements include conducting a detailed pricing strategy analysis, since Starbucks has over one thousand stores in the UK, it has the capability to experiment with various price points, keeping supply and branding centralized. Furthermore, with prominent competition like Costa and Greggs, competitor benchmarking is easy, and will aid in avoiding margin compressions, while serving the price sensitive regions. Starbucks prides itself on its variation in menus across the globe and ethical sourcing, which can readily be extended to the UK market incorporating localized flavours, without re-inventing operations. Delivering a more personalised in-store experience would require enhanced employee training programs emphasising customer engagement and service quality. Finally, successful execution depends on close collaboration across HR, product development, operations, marketing, and store management teams to ensure coherent implementation and consistency across all UK locations.

4.2 Feasibility

A. Pricing Model Implementation
   Feasibility: High: Regional pricing is a phenomenon that is followed globally, leading to easy and flexible operational implementation for Starbucks in the UK.

B. Menu & Store Localisation
   Feasibility: High: Initial investment required, however, Starbucks can achieve economies of scale, given the plethora of stores in the UK and globally.

C. Training and Service Enhancement
   Feasibility: High: Relies on expanding current training systems with minimal capital expenditure and therefore a tolerable risk

5. Validation

To analyse how pricing, an Americanised global strategy, and service experience may have influenced Starbucks' market position in the UK, we built a bespoke dataset of Google Maps reviews. Using a global Starbucks store database, we focused on the 10 most populated UK cities, where competitors are most concentrated. We then applied proportional random sampling to select 100 Starbucks stores based on each city's share of total stores. For example,

because London accounts for 63% of Starbucks locations across these ten cities, it was randomly allocated 63 stores.

For each store, we extracted 100 Google Maps reviews capturing the star rating, review text, review date, city, location details and store ownership type, resulting in a dataset of 10,000 observations. To ensure consistency and reduce bias, reviews were collected from most recent to older entries using exportcomments.com. Using this dataset, we applied NLP techniques to identify key themes, compute sentiment polarity scores and quantify customers' positive and negative experiences in overall and across regions.

5.1 Average Customer Ratings

Figure 1 shows the monthly average customer rating for Starbucks UK (1–5 scale) from 2022 to 2025, based on the Google reviews. Ratings remain mostly between 3.5 and 4.0, with moderate fluctuations over time. The trend suggests stable overall satisfaction, though some dips indicate periods of lower satisfaction, particularly around Oct–Dec 2023, Mar 2024, and Jul 2025.

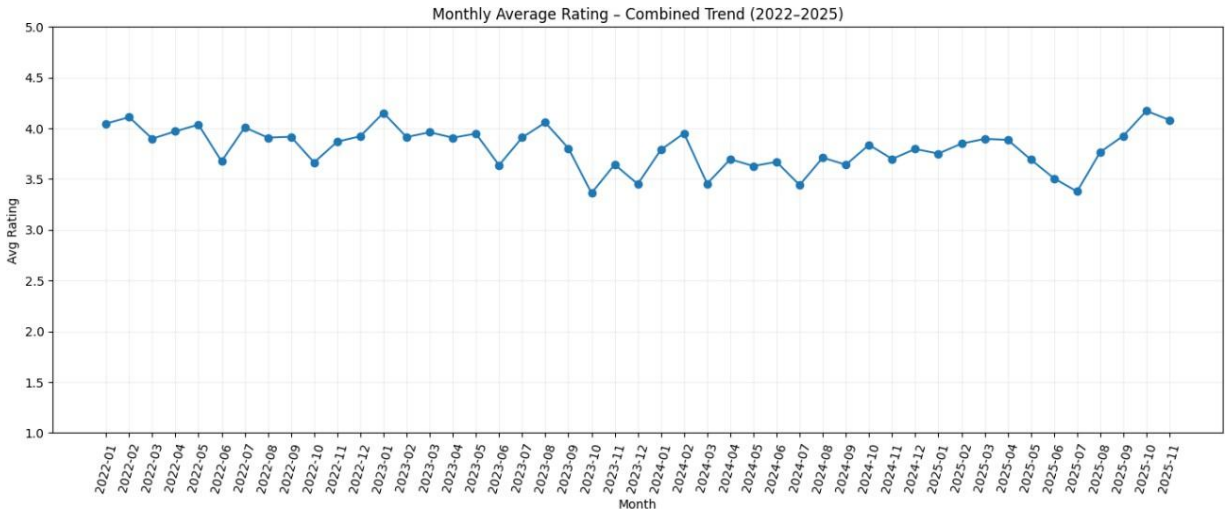

Figure 1: Average Ratings by Month

5.2 Average Sentiment Polarity

Explanation of the Graph

Figure 2 illustrates the average sentiment polarity across five experience dimensions at Starbucks UK (price, staff, quality, speed, and ambience), based on text-based customer reviews. Sentiment polarity ranges from -1 (very negative) to +1 (very positive), showing how positively or negatively customers feel about each aspect based on online feedback and

reviews. The bar heights represent average emotional response, highlighting which experience elements satisfy customers and which create dissatisfaction.

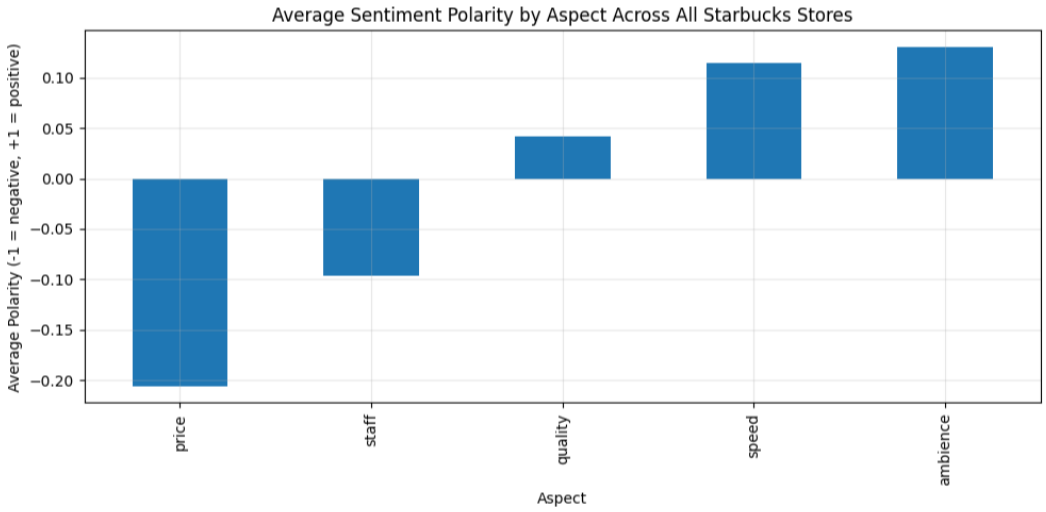

Figure 2: Average Sentiment Polarity

The sentiment analysis at Starbucks UK shows big differences in how customers feel about different parts of their experience. Price has the most negative sentiment, at about -0.20, which means that customers think Starbucks is too expensive. The staff's mood is slightly negative, at about -0.10, which means that service experiences aren't always consistent. Quality sentiment is slightly positive, which means that customers think the coffee is fine, but not great or worth the higher price. Speed works well, showing that service is reliable and quick during busy times. Ambience gets the most positive feedback, showing that people really like how comfortable Starbucks is.

Key Insights

The study shows that Starbucks' main strengths are its atmosphere and how it handles customer service, which fits well with its positioning. But big problems include people not liking the prices and not being sure how to talk to staff, which makes customers less loyal and less likely to come back. The quality of the product is fine, but not high enough to justify the current price, especially since there are strong competitors in the UK. Starbucks needs to raise the perceived value of its products and improve its customer service if it wants to stay competitive.

Impact on the Proposal

The negative feelings about prices show that we need a new way of setting prices in the UK, using things like value bundles or rewards for loyalty. Staff attitudes that range from neutral to negative suggest that training and more personalised interactions could help improve the consistency of customer service. Since speed and atmosphere are already good, adding more locally inspired menu items and experiences can build on what's already good and make it more in line with what UK customers want.

5.3 Regression Analysis

```
--- Regression: London vs Other Cities ---
                            OLS Regression Results
==============================================================================
Dep. Variable:                 rating   R-squared:                       0.007
Model:                            OLS   Adj. R-squared:                  0.007
Method:                 Least Squares   F-statistic:                     70.11
Date:                Tue, 18 Nov 2025   Prob (F-statistic):           6.35e-17
Time:                        18:54:24   Log-Likelihood:                -18254.
No. Observations:                9945   AIC:                         3.651e+04
Df Residuals:                    9943   BIC:                         3.653e+04
Df Model:                           1
Covariance Type:            nonrobust
==============================================================================
                 coef    std err          t      P>|t|      [0.025      0.975]
------------------------------------------------------------------------------
Intercept      3.9641      0.025    158.967      0.000       3.915       4.013
is_london     -0.2635      0.031     -8.373      0.000      -0.325      -0.202
==============================================================================
Omnibus:                     1556.898   Durbin-Watson:                   1.767
Prob(Omnibus):                  0.000   Jarque-Bera (JB):             1586.435
Skew:                          -0.913   Prob(JB):                         0.00
Kurtosis:                       2.297   Cond. No.                         3.04
==============================================================================

Notes:
[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.
```

Figure 3: Regression Table- London versus Other Cities

Interpretation of Regression Output and Strategic Implications

The regression results demonstrate a statistically significant difference between customer ratings in London and those in other UK cities. The variable *is_london* carries a negative coefficient of –0.2635, meaning London Starbucks stores, on average, receive 0.26 stars lower than non-London stores when holding all else constant. This difference is highly significant ($p < 0.001$), confirming that the lower performance in London is consistent and not random variation. With the intercept at 3.9641, we infer that stores outside London average around 3.96 stars, whereas London stores average closer to 3.70 stars, indicating a drop in perceived service quality. The low R^2 (0.007) is expected in single-variable regressions; its purpose here is not predictive power but to confirm directional differences between regions. Together, these results provide strong evidence of a geographic satisfaction gap and help identify London as a critical area requiring strategic focus.

From a strategic perspective, this regression output strengthens the proposed recommendations for improving customer experience, local adaptation, and competitive positioning. Since London stores consistently underperform, the city becomes an ideal priority test market for implementing new initiatives such as service quality upgrades, staff engagement training, localized menu offerings, and modified pricing strategies.

Improvements will not only address the largest satisfaction deficit but also generate highly visible outcomes in the UK's most competitive and heavily frequented market. The model supports the idea that customer dissatisfaction in London may stem from operational pressures unique to metropolitan areas: high footfall, longer queues, faster service expectations which aligns with the strategy to enhance service speed, personalization, and atmosphere. Successfully elevating London ratings would serve as proof of concept, allowing Starbucks to refine and scale these interventions nationwide, ultimately reinforcing brand loyalty and improving overall performance across the UK.

5.4 Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) Analysis

```
[55]: plot_topic(topics, topic_number=1)
      #topic 1: customer complaints about staff attitude

      #analysis:
      #problems mentioned: rude and unfriendly behaviour
      #Starbucks should look into: improve customer service training and monitor staff interactions
```

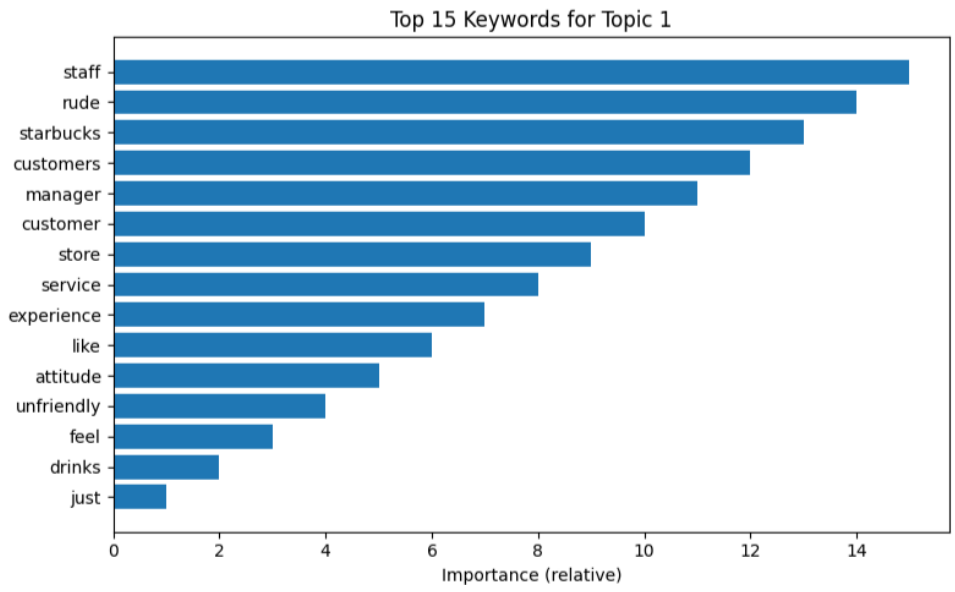

Figure 4: Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) Analysis

LDA Topic Modelling Output

This visualisation shows the results of applying Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) to Starbucks UK customer reviews to identify key themes. LDA automatically finds patterns in word usage and groups frequently co-occurring terms into meaningful topics.

Topic 1 highlights negative customer service experiences, with the top keywords - staff, rude, manager, attitude, unfriendly, experience, and service - indicating recurring complaints about staff behaviour rather than isolated incidents.

These LDA results strongly support a plan to improve how employees and customers interact in all UK Starbucks stores. Staff behaviour and rudeness are clearly identified as a major source of dissatisfaction by the model. This shows that the problem is widespread and not just one case. This evidence supports specific actions like better training for customer service, up-to-date performance measures, better supervision, and regular audits of service quality.

Using topic-modelling insights makes sure that the strategy is based on real customer concerns instead of assumptions. This helps Starbucks decide which actions will have the biggest impact. Since bad service experiences keep happening, it is necessary and valuable to spend money on structured training, consistent service standards, and better feedback systems. Ultimately, addressing these staff-related issues could significantly improve customer satisfaction, online ratings, and brand perception, particularly in competitive regions like London.

5.5 Other market trends and competitors' analysis

Industry data from Statista and Allegra World Coffee Portal indicate that the UK coffee shop market has grown over the past decade, despite economic uncertainty and shifting consumer behaviour. Revenue forecasts show strong expansion across all major segments, with Roast Coffee remaining the dominant category at £5.56 billion and Instant Coffee ranking lower at £4.83 billion. The upward revenue trajectory observed in the chart highlights the resilience of the UK's specialty coffee market and reinforces the attractiveness of the sector for strategic investment.

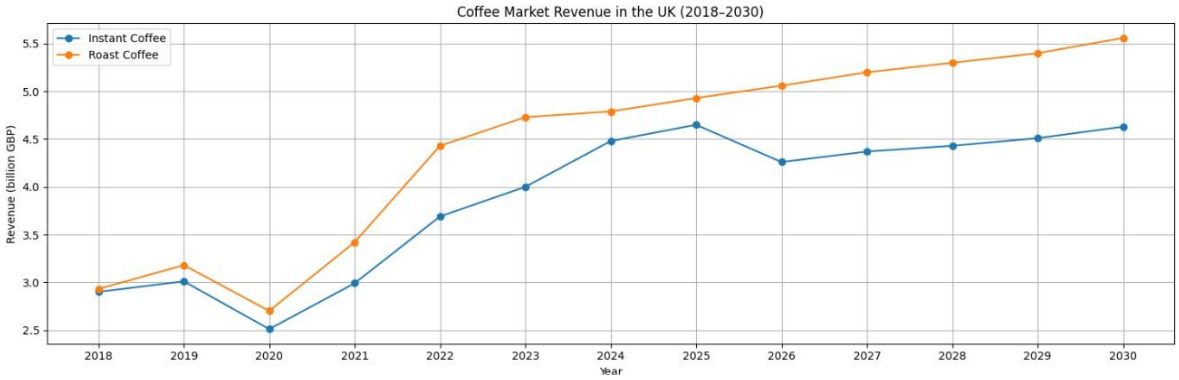

Figure 5: Market Revenue in UK (2018-2030)

According to Allegra World Coffee Portal (Jan 2025), Costa Coffee holds the largest store footprint in the UK, with 2,671 outlets, followed by Greggs and Starbucks with 2,610 and 1,356 stores respectively. The multi-year comparison shows Costa's consistent leadership in unit expansion and Greggs' growing presence driven by its value-oriented positioning. Starbucks, the only non-British brand among the top chains, maintains a steady but smaller footprint relative to domestic competitors. The pattern illustrates how market share in physical locations is shaped by pricing strategy, convenience, and brand familiarity, factors that are influential in the UK's competitive high-street landscape.

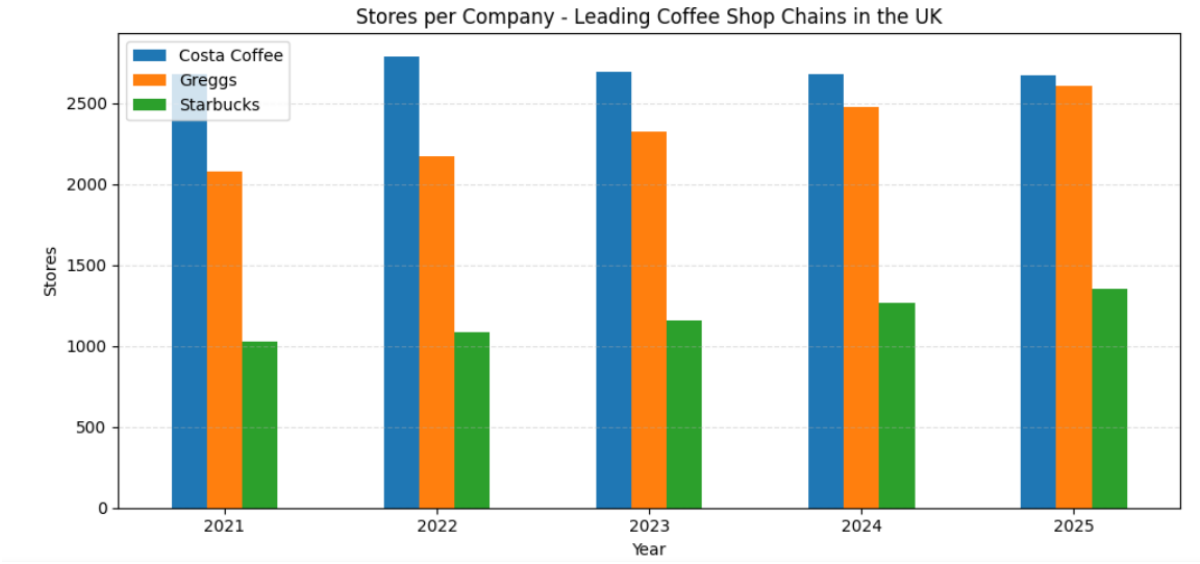

Figure 6: Stores per Company

The price comparison analysis reveals how Starbucks is positioned relative to Costa, Pret, Black Sheep, and Greggs in both entry price and average price. While Costa and Pret offer similar quality perceptions at slightly lower price points, Greggs clearly dominates the price-sensitive segment, offering entry products up to 30% cheaper than Starbucks. Conversely, Black Sheep operates at the highest average price, appealing to a niche premium audience. Taken together, the pricing structure underscores that Starbucks competes in a mid-premium segment yet faces increasing pressure from Greggs' affordability and Costa's broader UK presence. This reinforces that a targeted reduction in Starbucks' coffee prices would strengthen its competitive position, allowing the brand to better match the pricing strategies of Costa and Greggs and capture consumers that have higher price sensitivity.

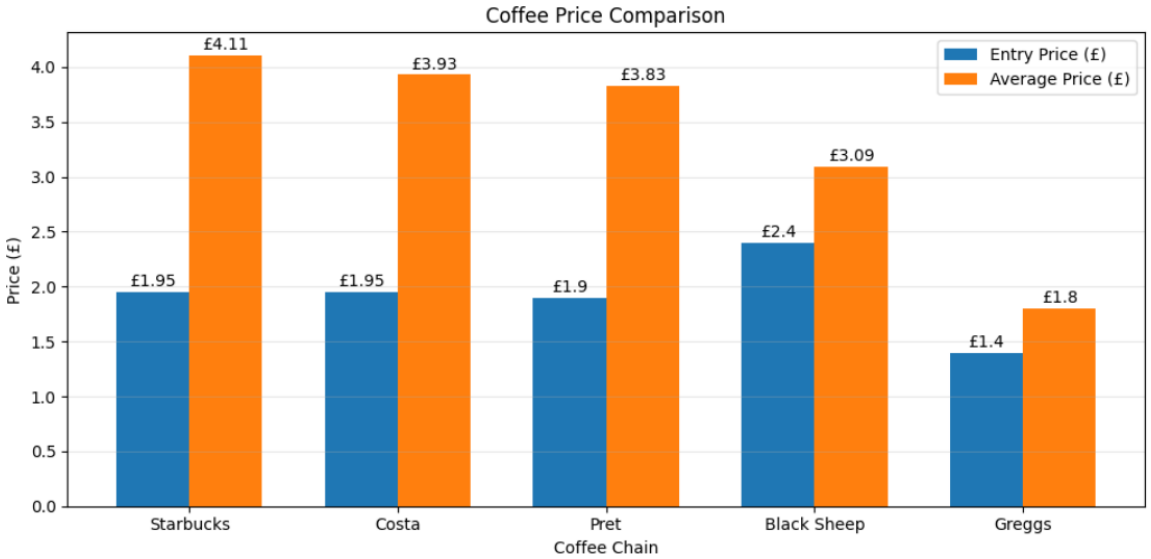

Figure 7: Price Comparison Between Major Players

6. Risk Assessment and its Mitigation

6.1 Competitors imitating on price

A major risk for Starbucks is competitors lowering prices while maintaining strong service quality. A price war could attract price-sensitive customers, erode Starbucks' market share, weaken differentiation, and pressure margins. Targeted promotions or bundled offers from rivals could further widen the perceived value gap, increasing the risk of customer defection even among those who typically choose Starbucks for its experience.

This risk can be mitigated by strengthening Starbucks' loyalty ecosystem and enhancing its non-price value proposition. A more robust loyalty programme with tiered rewards, personalised offers, exclusive seasonal benefits, and experiential perks increases switching costs by rewarding long-term behaviour. Features such as faster points accumulation, early access to limited-edition drinks, or partner-brand collaborations reinforce exclusivity and attachment. By enriching the customer journey rather than competing on price, Starbucks maintains its premium positioning while still giving customers meaningful incentives to stay. Over time, stronger loyalty and emotional connection reduce the appeal of lower-priced competitors where customers have no accumulated value.

6.2 Global Operational Disruption from Localised Strategy Expansion

A major risk emerges if Starbucks must extend its UK-style localisation strategy region-specific flavours and cultural alignment to other international markets. While localisation can boost relevance, scaling it globally increases operational complexity, supply chain demands, product development costs, and research requirements. Cultural preferences vary significantly: markets like Japan may embrace regional seasonal flavours, while markets like India with vast taste diversity and entrenched preferences may reject forced localisation, leading to product failure and financial losses. Uncertain acceptance across culturally distinct markets makes global rollout inherently risky.

This risk can be mitigated through controlled, data-driven experimentation. Starbucks can introduce limited-time or region-specific drinks in select markets using an A/B testing model to observe real behaviour, track purchases, and collect feedback through surveys and digital channels. Incentives such as loyalty points or early-access perks can increase participation. This test-and-learn approach reduces financial exposure and ensures only concepts with proven regional demand are scaled.

6.3 Staff Behaviour/ Trained employee

Employee training carries the risk of staff leaving before Starbucks benefits from their improved skills especially in a high-turnover sector like hospitality. Although training enhances service quality, the investment may be lost if employees move to competitors or other industries.

Mitigation requires pairing training with strong retention strategies. Longer-term contracts, loyalty bonuses, staged pay increases, and benefits that unlock over time encourage employees to stay long enough for Starbucks to gain returns on its investment. These measures promote stability, commitment, and sustained service quality.

7. Scenario Analysis

Strategic planning requires considering how alternative future conditions might impact the effectiveness of Starbucks' proposed strategy. Two plausible scenarios are examined below, each shaped by different customer expectations and market dynamics in the UK. By assessing Starbucks' performance under these scenarios, we can evaluate the adaptability and resilience of the strategy while identifying specific actions needed to succeed in each environment.

Scenario 1: Customers Prioritize Service Quality, Ambience, and Personalization

In this future, UK customers value premium coffee but place even greater emphasis on service quality, ambience, and personalised interactions. Price becomes less important as long as the experience feels superior and emotionally meaningful.

LDA analysis of customer reviews highlights recurring keywords such as *service, staff, friendly, helpful, clean,* and *amazing*, showing that positive experiences are tied not just to product quality but also to interpersonal connection and store environment. The prominence of terms like *staff* and *friendly* confirms that human interaction and consistent service are central to customer satisfaction.

These insights support a strategy focused on frontline training, personalised service models, employee empowerment, and ambience improvements. Operational efficiency alone is insufficient in this scenario; competitive advantage comes from emotional engagement and experiential quality. Enhancing digital personalisation through Starbucks Rewards and tailored suggestions can further strengthen the experience, while ensuring technology complements not replaces human hospitality.

This strategy performs strongly because it directly targets the factors customers value most: comfort, consistency, and meaningful human connection. LDA insights confirm that these elements already drive much of the customer conversation, making them dependable foundations for future differentiation and investment.

```
[16]: plot_topic(topics, topic_number=4)
```

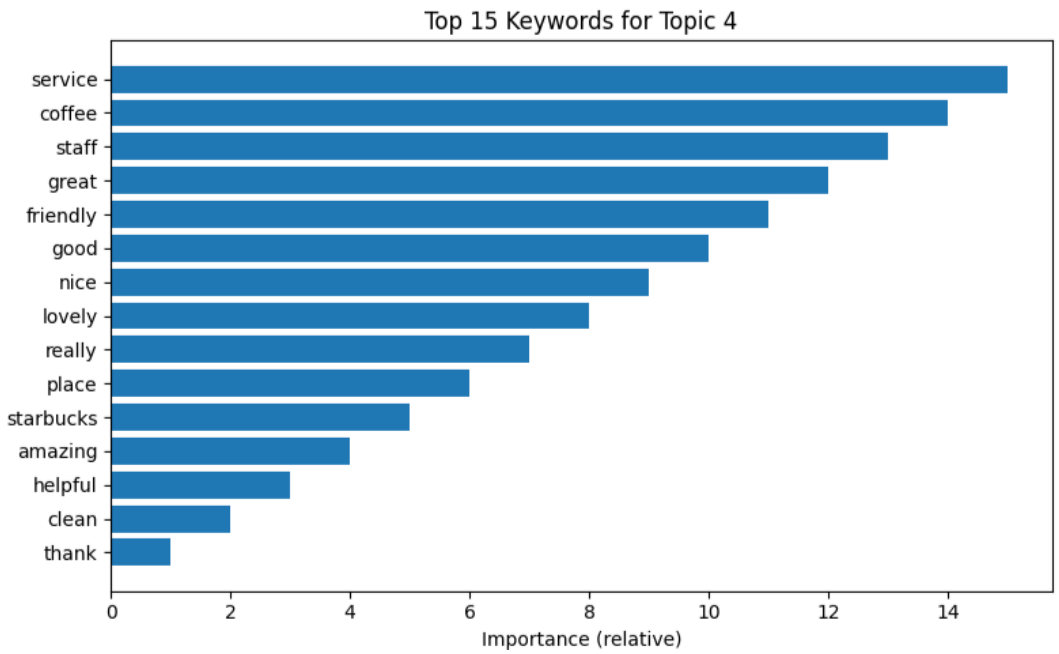

Figure 8: LDA Analysis on Customer Priority

Scenario 2: UK Customers Shift Toward Locally Perceived Brands

In this future, UK consumers increasingly prefer brands seen as authentically local, driven by cultural identity, community loyalty, and support for home-grown businesses. As an American multinational, Starbucks may face resistance regardless of adaptations, since its global image limits its ability to meet expectations rooted in local distinctiveness.

A strong strategy in this environment is for Starbucks to acquire successful UK cafés while allowing them to operate under their existing brands. This mirrors approaches used by firms like Mars, which preserve the independent identity of acquired brands so customers remain loyal even though ownership changes.

This strategy works because it protects the authenticity of consumers value, avoids the forced repositioning of Starbucks as "local," and uses the acquired cafés' existing supply chains, reducing operational disruption. It also converts competitors into portfolio assets, diversifying revenue and easing competitive pressure. By keeping ownership low-profile,

Starbucks maintains customer trust and avoids backlash tied to visible multinational involvement.

8. Conclusion

To secure long-term competitiveness in the UK market, Starbucks must evolve from a primarily global, standardised model toward a more locally attuned and value-sensitive strategy. By addressing pricing barriers, embedding UK-specific cultural relevance, and elevating service consistency, Starbucks can strengthen customer loyalty and differentiate itself beyond the premium image alone. Deeper partnership with local cafés, suppliers, and communities can further reinforce its position as an authentic part of the UK café landscape. Collectively, these changes allow Starbucks to sustain premium brand equity while overcoming the growing pressure from lower-priced, faster-moving competitors.

Starbucks should begin by piloting regional pricing, value-tier drink options, and bundled loyalty offers to test price sensitivity while protecting margins. In parallel, a UK-focused menu and supplier strategy should be developed to introduce locally inspired food and drink items, supported by selective store redesigns that better reflect British café culture and hybrid working habits. Service consistency can be strengthened through refreshed training, performance incentives, and greater store level flexibility during peak periods.

9. Use of AI

Generative AI (ChatGPT) was used to support specific stages of the project, always as an assistive tool rather than a replacement for analytical or decision-making work.

AI Estimated UK-only yearly revenue:

Generative AI (ChatGPT) was used during the market and competitor analysis phase, specifically when we needed an indicative view of the UK revenues of the main coffee chains in our benchmark set. The model produced an estimated revenue table for Starbucks, Costa Coffee, Pret A Manger, Caffè Nero, Black Sheep Coffee and Greggs. We used them as an input to scale our pricing scenarios (for example, to approximate how changes in average coffee price might translate into revenue exposure for larger vs smaller chains).

AI support during risk analysis:

During the risk and scenario analysis phase, the team used Generative AI as a decision-support tool to clarify the assignment requirements and guide the process. The tool helped us

understand the conceptual differences between risks and scenarios, provided step-by-step guidance on how to identify, prioritise and mitigate risks within the context of our strategy.

10. Use of Project Management Tools and Methodologies

Throughout the project, the team applied project management practices using Microsoft Planner as the main tool. We organised our work using a Kanban-based workflow, structured around the “To Do", "Doing", and "Done” buckets. Tasks were also grouped by week (week 1, week 2, etc) and by aspect (company related, data related, etc), which helped us have an organised view of the overall progress. We complemented this structure with weekly meetings, allowing us to discuss key findings, and make decisions at each stage of the project.

Each meeting was documented directly within Planner using detailed notes, checklists, and summaries, following PMI documentation principles. This ensured that all decisions and dataset evaluations were recorded systematically throughout the project.

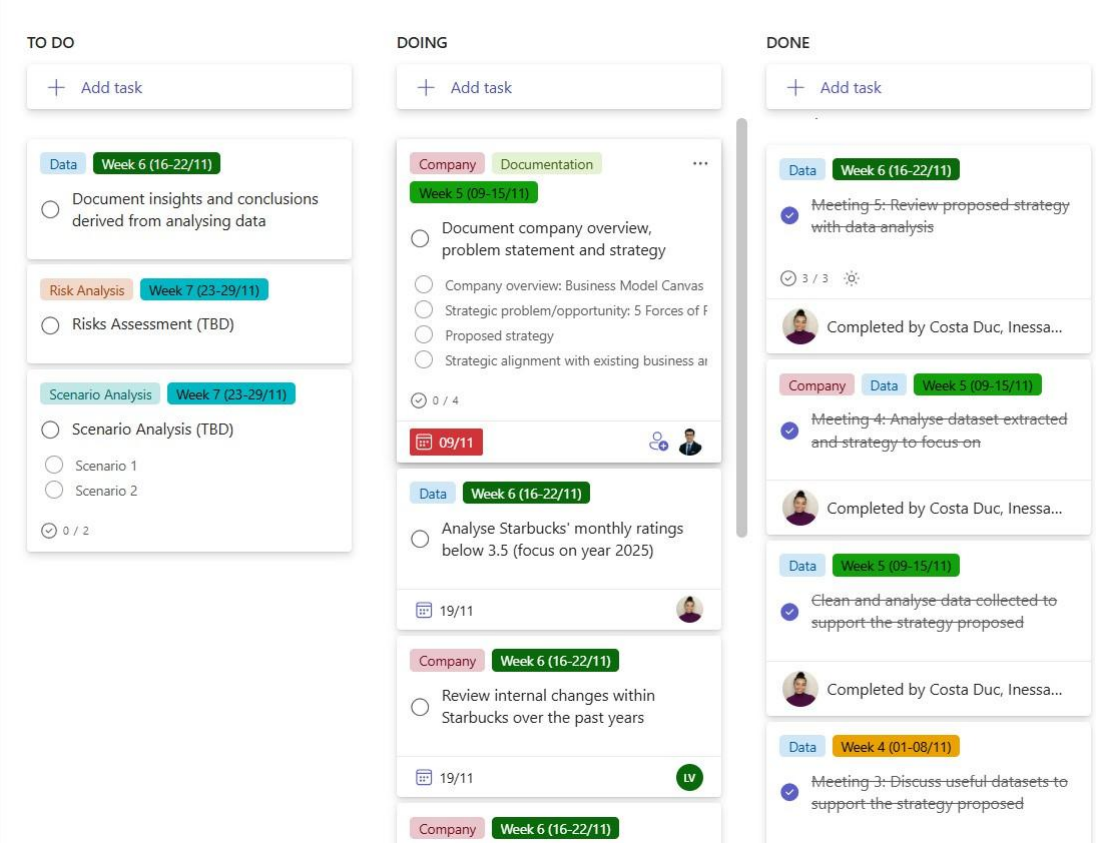

Figure 9: Project Management (Kanban)

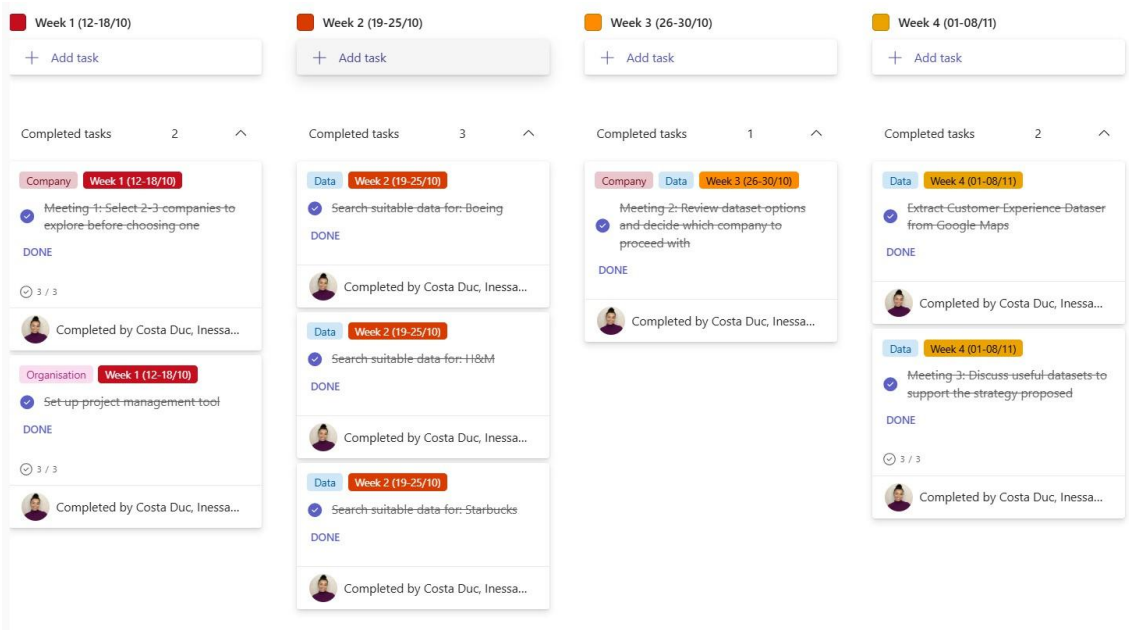

Figure 10: Project Management (Weekly Progress)

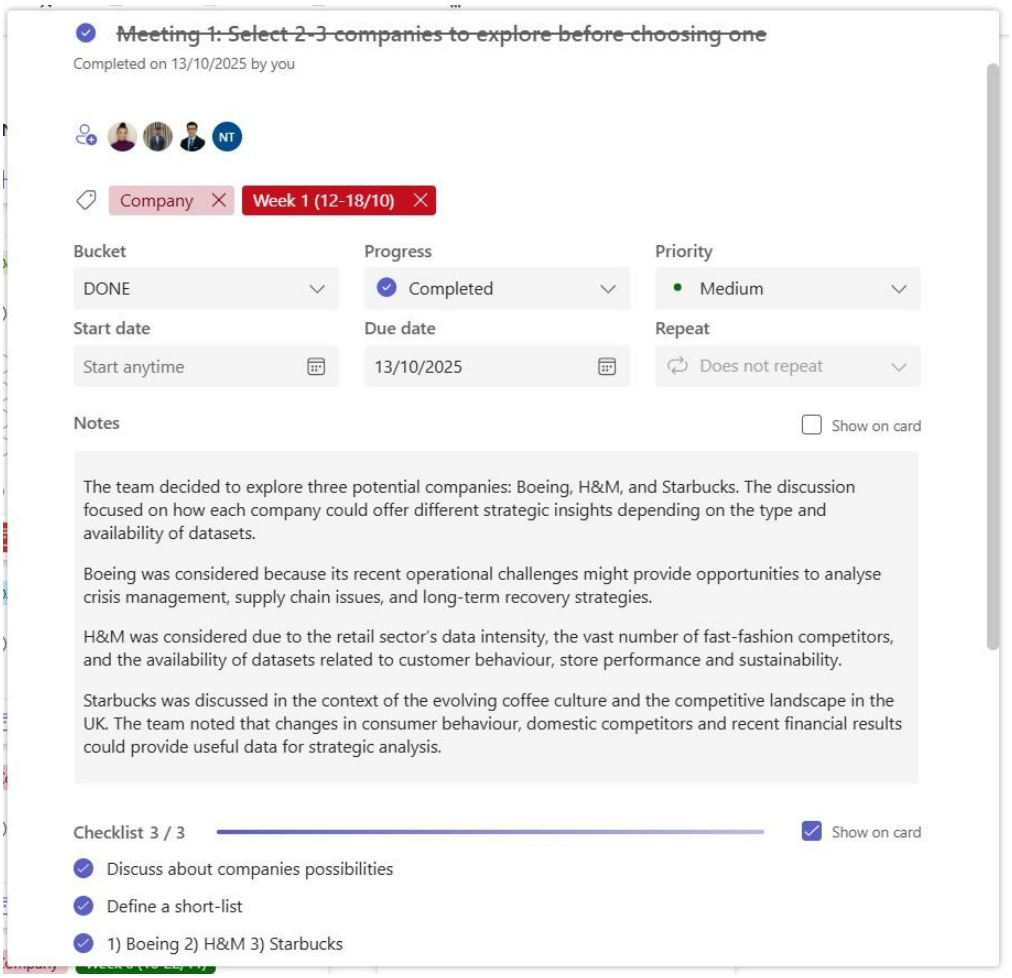

Figure 11: Project Management (Example of Meeting Summary)

11. Attribution Statement

Inessa Costa Duc

Inessa managed the project, assigning and communicating the tasks to the team. She also contributed to the analytical work, including extracting customer-experience datasets, performing EDA, and analysing competitor and market trends.

Kakajan Berdiyev

Kakajan contributed to the company-level analysis by reviewing Starbucks' current market positioning and analysing its internal strategic developments. He also supported the evaluation of datasets during project meetings.

Mohammad Talha Nasir

Talha contributed to the analytical work, including extracting customer-experience datasets and performing EDA. He also conducted competitor-revenue research and the documentation of the proposed strategy and its feasibility.

Vedant Bhatia

Vedant contributed to the analytical work, leading key data evaluations, particularly the customer-sentiment analysis. He also conducted and documented the Risk Assessment and Scenario Analysis discussions.

Vidhi Laddha

Vidhi contributed to the analytical work by developing the regression modelling. She was also responsible for drafting and revising the written report, ensuring that the most strategic and relevant content was presented clearly.

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